ERA 18

The Theaters of War

1942 – 1945

Europe · the Pacific · the atomic bomb

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the Allies win a two-front war—and at what cost?

KEY TERMS

D-Day · the Battle of Midway · island hopping · the Manhattan Project · Hiroshima & Nagasaki

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.13 · AMSCO Ch. 7.13

FIGHTING ON OPPOSITE SIDES OF THE WORLD

A Two-Front War

Two Theaters of War

I

The European Theater

Against Nazi Germany and Italy—led with Britain and the Soviet Union.

II

The Pacific Theater

Against Japan—a naval and island war led largely by the U.S.

III

'Germany First'

The Allies agreed to defeat Hitler first, then focus on Japan.

The European Theater



- The Soviets broke the German advance at **Stalingrad** (1942–43).
- On **D-Day** (June 6, 1944), Allied forces under **Eisenhower** stormed **Normandy**.
- After the **Battle of the Bulge**, the Allies drove into Germany.

Victory in Europe

- Caught between the Soviets and the Western Allies, Germany collapsed.
- Hitler died as Berlin fell.
- Germany surrendered on **V-E Day**—May 8, 1945.



The Pacific Theater



- The **Battle of Midway** (1942) turned the tide against Japan.
- The U.S. used '**island hopping**' to advance toward Japan.
- Battles like **Iwo Jima** and Okinawa were savage and costly.

SECTION

The War's End

The Atomic Bomb



- The secret **Manhattan Project**, led by **Oppenheimer**, built the atomic bomb.
- In August 1945, the U.S. dropped bombs on **Hiroshima** and **Nagasaki**.
- Over 200,000 died—and the nuclear age began.

Japan Surrenders

- Facing atomic devastation and a Soviet declaration of war, Japan surrendered.
- **Truman** had made the fateful decision to use the bomb.
- **V-J Day**—the formal surrender came aboard the USS Missouri, September 2, 1945.



Who Fought



- The **Tuskegee Airmen** were among the most decorated pilots of the war.
- **Navajo Code Talkers** sent unbreakable messages in the Pacific.
- Women, Black, Latino, and Native American troops all served with distinction.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Theaters of War

1. In **Europe**, **Stalingrad**, **D-Day**, and the **Battle of the Bulge** brought victory on **V-E Day**.
2. In the **Pacific**, **Midway** and **island hopping** pushed the U.S. toward Japan.
3. The **atomic bombs** on **Hiroshima and Nagasaki** ended the war—and opened the nuclear age.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Theaters of War

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the Allies turned the tide in **both** the European and Pacific theaters.

COMPARISON

Compare the war in **Europe** with the war in the **Pacific**.

ARGUMENTATION

Was dropping the **atomic bomb** justified? Make and defend a claim.

Up next — **Class 50: The Home Front** (mobilization, opportunity & internment)